

Air travel in the “golden age” of the propliner came far closer to matching the airlines’ publicity image of comfort and glamour than had ever been possible before. Turbulence was much reduced by flying at high altitude and soundproofing cut down engine noise. Journey times were progressively shorter – the San Francisco-to-New York route, for example, came down from around 11 hours in an early-model Constellation to about eight hours in a mid-1950s DC-7. Although the pressure toward economy flight was always there, propliners often provided very spacious accommodation. Many had bunk beds, and the Stratocruiser had a downstairs lounge and bar reached by a spiral staircase.

However, for those who could afford it, flying remained something of an adventure. The passengers on postwar transatlantic services, with their refueling stops at the bleak outposts of Gander, Newfoundland, and Shannon in Ireland, could not regard their experience as mundane. Flights were still subject to delays or enforced stops for bad weather, and many of the propliners were plagued by engine trouble. Cockpit technology was advancing fast – for example, on-board radars came into general use during the 1950s – but flying was still very hands-on.

Advent of jet airliners

The propliners of the 1940s and 1950s were machines of great power and their achievements were impressive. Through the 1950s they developed the range to offer nonstop transoceanic and transcontinental flights. The DC-6B allowed SAS to start the first scheduled transpolar flights in 1954, linking northern Europe to America’s west coast. By 1957 the Lockheed 1649 Starliner was flying from Los Angeles to London nonstop in 19 hours. But the 1950s propliners represented a technology that had been pushed as far as it would go.

The transfer of jet technology to commercial aviation was not straightforward. Economy and reliability were the essence of passenger operations, but early jet engines could provide neither. They used up enormous quantities of fuel and made heavy demands on maintenance staff. No wonder American airlines and manufacturers, with their heavy commitment to piston-engined airliners, ignored the jet for so long after the war. The British, by contrast, found themselves world leaders in jet-engine design after the forced withdrawal of Germany from the field. They had every interest in pursuing jet aviation and soon set the pace, first with turboprops and then with turbojets.

The turboprop was, in retrospect, clearly a transitional technology. It used the hot gas inside a jet engine to drive propellers, giving greater power and speed than a piston engine, but much better fuel economy than contemporary turbojets. The first turboprop airliner, the Vickers Viscount,

POSTWAR PROPLINERS

AFTER THE WAR, piston-engined, propeller-driven airliners were not a serious challenge until the late 1950s. The propliners were able to hold off the challenge of turboprops and jets for more than a decade, not only because of the difficulty of developing a reliable jet airliner, but also because they were such excellent airplanes. Far superior in comfort, range, and speed to most prewar airliners, airplanes such as the Constellation and the DC-7 could operate transcontinental services that outclassed the service offered by ships and trains. By 1957, propliners were carrying more people across the Atlantic than ocean liners. Keys to their success included pressurized cabins and more powerful, efficient engines.



BRITISH AMBASSADOR

One of the most elegant aircraft ever built, the 30-seat Airspeed Ambassador, which entered service in 1952, was intended to revive the UK's civil airline network.

Boeing Model 377 Stratocruiser

The bulbous Stratocruiser was deceptively fast and its size evoked a prewar atmosphere of spacious elegance. The new double-decked fuselage was grafted onto the wings, engines, and tail of the B-29 Super Fortress bomber.

As usual Pan American was the first customer, putting the 377 into service in February 1949 but it was not destined to be a commercial success for Boeing. Only 55 Model 377s were built, due to their high operating costs and also because each cost \$1.75 million against \$1 million for the competing Lockheed Constellation and Douglas DC-6.



ENGINE 4 x 3,500hp P&W R-4360B Wasp Major 28 radial	
WINGSPAN 141ft 3in (43.1m)	LENGTH 110ft 4in (33.6m)
CRUISING SPEED 340mph (547kph)	
PASSENGERS 55–112	CREW 5

Breguet 763 Deux-Ponts/Provence

Sadly the story of the Deux-Ponts is typical of early postwar attempts to build a successful airliner. The first bulbous double-decker Deux-Ponts flew in February 1949, following a French government order in 1947 for 15 aircraft. To improve its commercial potential, the following aircraft had American engines in place of the prototype's French power plants. Despite lengthy military trials, no more B-761s were built, although 12 of the improved B-763 Provences were flown by Air France.

ENGINE 4 x 2,100hp P&W R-2800 Double Wasp 18 radial	
WINGSPAN 136ft 8in (41.7m)	LENGTH 94ft 2in (28.7m)
CRUISING SPEED 286mph (320kph)	
PASSENGERS 101	CREW 4



Bristol Brabazon (Type 167)

The Bristol Brabazon was named after Lord Brabazon, who led the committee which recommended the types of postwar civil aircraft Britain should build. The enormous Brabazon was, in fact, the least successful and the only model finally flew on September 4, 1949. It was powered by eight engines coupled in pairs to four counter-rotating propellers. Sadly it never went into production, and the aircraft was scrapped in 1953, having flown less than 400 hours.



ENGINE 8 x 2,500hp Bristol Centaurus 18-cylinder radial	
WINGSPAN 230ft (70.1m)	LENGTH 177ft (54m)
CRUISING SPEED 250mph (402kph)	
PASSENGERS 100	CREW 12